

CHAPTER FOUR

Non-official Enterprise in Education (1813-53)
and Wood's Education Despatch (1854)

The history of the official attempts to educate the people of India in the period between the Charter Act of 1813 and Wood's Education Despatch of 1854 was described in the preceding chapter. We shall now describe the non-official attempts in the field of education (1813-53) and close the study of this period by summarising and evaluating the principal directions of the Education Despatch of 1854 which is the most important educational document under the Company and is even referred to, by some historians, as the "Magna Charta of English Education in India".¹

The non-official attempts of this period can be grouped under four principal heads: (a) the educational institutions conducted by the missionaries; (b) the educational institutions conducted by officials of the Company in their individual capacity or by non-official Englishmen resident in India; (c) the educational institutions of the modern type conducted by Indians themselves; and (d) the indigenous educational institutions. The official attempts to expand and improve the last group of educational institutions have already been studied in the preceding chapter. We shall now deal, in some detail, with the three remaining groups of educational institutions.

Missionary Educational Enterprise (1813-33): It was pointed out in Chapter II that the Charter Act of 1813 opened India to Missionary Societies. Consequently, the period from 1813 to 1833 was one of great mission activity in all parts of the Company's Dominions. The missionary societies that were already working

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, p. 364.

in India expanded their activities and new societies came into the field. Among these latter, special mention must be made of the General Baptist Missionary Society, the London Missionary Society, the Church Missionary Society, the Wesleyan Mission and the Scotch Missionary Society.

Three features regarding the educational work of the missionaries deserve special notice. Firstly, it must be remembered that education was never the *main* object of the missionaries. They aimed at conversions and were obliged to take up educational work in order to meet the needs of the converted population and, more especially, to train up Indian assistants for their proselytizing activities. Secondly, the importance which the early missionaries attached to the study of modern Indian languages deserves special mention. They had to work among the lowest classes of society who could not understand any language except their own. Hence the missionaries assiduously studied the Indian languages, prepared dictionaries, wrote books on grammar, and translated the Bible into them. It is worthy of note that most of the earlier mission schools gave instruction through the mother-tongue of the pupils and it never occurred to the Indian missionaries to say that "the dialects commonly spoken among the natives... are so poor and rude that... it will not be easy to translate any valuable work into them"—a statement regarding the truth of which the Company's officials were entirely convinced! Consequently, the honour of having compiled the first school text-books in Indian languages goes to the missionaries. Thirdly, the missionaries did extremely valuable pioneer work in the field of the education of women—a "dangerous" area in which the officials of this period refused to tread. The wives of the missionaries and some women mission workers took the lead in this matter and began to work for the spread of education among women. This was done through three types of activities, viz., (a) opening of day schools for Indian girls, (b) establishment of Orphan Homes, and (c) domestic instruction or *zenana* education in the families of the middle and higher classes.

Another important development of this period was that the relations between the Company and the missionaries began to improve slowly and steadily. Reference has already been made to the extremely strained relations that existed between them in

the period from 1793 to 1813. But the Charter Act of 1813 turned a new page. The officials now realised that missionaries must be tolerated and allowed to work; on the other hand, the missionaries also appear to have shown better tact and discretion in their work of proselytization. Consequently, the relations between these two groups of workers improved considerably. The Company not only recognised the utility of the educational work of the missionaries, but occasionally sanctioned grants-in-aid for it; the officials of the Company often worked hand in hand with missionaries on Societies established for the spread of education among the Indian people; and on the whole, it may be said that the distrust and hostility which were so significant a feature of the official attitude towards missionaries in the earlier period were now a thing of the past.

Missionary Educational Enterprise (1833-53): The freedom given by the Charter Act of 1813 had so far been taken advantage of principally by the missionary societies from the United Kingdom. But the Charter Act of 1833 brought missions from other countries also on the scene.¹ Prominent among them were the German and American missions. The *Basel Mission Society* began work at Mangalore in 1834 and soon extended its activities very largely in the Kannada and Malayalam territory. Other important German Societies were the *Protestant Lutheran Missionary Society* (founded at Dresden in 1836) and *Women's Association of Education of Females in the Orient* (founded in Berlin in 1842) both of which did considerable missionary work in India. Equally important was the appearance of the "well-manned and richly financed" American Societies amongst which may be mentioned the American Baptist Union, the American Board, and the American Presbyterian Mission Board North.

In the period prior to 1833, the elementary schools teaching through the modern Indian languages formed the bulk of missionary educational enterprise. But between 1833 and 1853, the

¹"At the same time, India was thrown open to the whole world and any and every honest man who liked might settle there. This provision opened up India likewise to the missionary activity of other nations. It was in this year that the missionary labours of the Non-English Missionary Societies began in India."—Richter: *A History of Missions in India*, p. 192.

missionaries shifted the emphasis to secondary schools and colleges teaching through English. This change was dictated by two considerations: the first was the belief, already referred to, that a study of Western science and literature would inevitably be followed by a conversion to Christianity and the second was the desire to convert the upper classes of the Hindu Society. The missionaries knew that the upper classes desired to study English for the worldly advantages it brought and that they would not mind joining a mission school (which they otherwise disliked) for the sake of learning English. The mission schools and colleges, therefore, with their compulsory teaching of the Bible, gave the missionaries an excellent and probably their only opportunity to contact the boys and girls of the higher castes and to preach the Gospel to them. A lead in this direction was given by Alexander Duff, the greatest missionary of this period who himself started an English school in Calcutta in 1830. Duff's faith in the potential power of English education to secure converts soon infected almost all the missionaries working in the field of Indian education and English schools conducted by missionaries began to multiply very rapidly after 1830. It was realised even then that the Indian pupils joined the missionary schools, not for the sake of religious instruction, but to learn English with a view to securing employment under Government. It was also soon discovered that the pupils put up with the compulsory Bible period as a matter of necessity and that they generally showed no interest in the teachings of Christ. But with the infinite patience and the incorrigible optimism that are characteristic of the missionary spirit, the workers of the Indian missions toiled in English schools in the hope that "some seed at least is sure a strike". The disillusionment came later—by about 1870—but, so far as the period under review was concerned, the hopes of a plentiful harvest of conversions through English schools ran high. Consequently,

the quarter century, 1830-57, is the *age of the mission school*. During that period the Government—in spite of the good intentions of Bentinck—lay really in an apathy which we find it hard to understand; for three years Lord Ellenbrough was Governor-General, a man who regarded the political ruin of the English power as the inevitable consequence of the education of the

Hindus! Hence at that time the mission school exercised a dominating influence over Indian Thought which it is difficult to estimate nowadays. In Bombay Dr. John Wilson (after Duff the most brilliant Scotch missionary of the day), founded the magnificent college which afterwards bore his name. At Madras Anderson and Braidwood opened the General Assembly's school in 1837, which, under the genial direction of Dr. Miller, the most famous educational missionary alive, has become the "Christian College". At Nagpur in Central India, Stephen Hislop opened in 1844 the fourth of his Society's colleges. In 1853 the Church Missionary Society founded St. John's College at Agra, the first principal of which was the future Bishop French; in 1841 Robert Noble opened the "Noble" College at Masulipatam. These were the most famous of the colleges which were erected in rapid succession in the most widely separated parts of the country under the direct influence and inspiration of Duff, to say nothing of other colleges like those built at Calcutta, Madras, and Bombay by the National Church of Scotland.¹

This growth of missionary enterprise, whether in the sphere of proselytization or of education, was greatly facilitated by the cordial relations that prevailed in this period between the officials of the Company and the missionaries. This was due to two causes: *firstly*, the period of 1833-53 was one of great reforms and liberal ideas in the social life of England with the result that many of the Company's officials were themselves inspired by missionary zeal; *secondly*, the fear that interference with religious institutions would be greatly resented by Hindus and Muslims—it was this fear that had mainly led to the adoption of the policy of religious neutrality in the earlier decades—was not entertained seriously during this period. One test case was made out in the abolition of Sati. The opponents of this reforms had argued that the attempt would lead to revolts. But nothing of the kind happened and enlightened Hindus came forward to support the reform and thank the Government. Another instance of successful intervention with the religious institutions lay in the management by the Company of rich Hindu temples and Hindu religious fairs—an act that aroused no opposition and brought some

¹Richter: *A History of Missions in India*, pp. 183-4.

profits to the Company to boot. The officials of this period, therefore, were not afraid to associate themselves openly with the missionaries and encourage their efforts. The relations between the missionaries and the officials of the Company, therefore, were extremely cordial between 1833 and 1853—a fact that is in direct contrast to the strained relations that existed between them in the period from 1793 to 1813, or to the none too warm feelings that prevailed in the two decades between 1813 and 1833.

Fairly comprehensive statistics of missionary activity are available.¹ It will be seen from them that the mission activity in education was almost equal to official enterprise (which had 1,474 institutions with 67,569 pupils) if the Protestant organisations alone are considered. But the total mission activity in education—both Protestant and Roman Catholic—must certainly have exceeded the official enterprise. It would, therefore, be correct to say that, in 1854, the largest part of educational enterprise in India (indigenous schools apart) was provided, not by the Company, but by the missionaries. It can also be seen that the extent of mission activity varied from Province to Province. It was extremely widespread and strong in Madras partly because it began very early (1706) and partly because the extremely hard plight of the Harijans in the South provided a more fruitful soil for conversions. It was weakest in the Punjab, the next Provinces in order of increasing strength being Central India, N.-W.P., Bombay and Bengal.

Claims of Missionary Enterprise: When Section 43 of the Charter Act of 1813 was passed, the object of Parliament was *not* to secure financial assistance to the missionary educational institutions (as some missionaries seemed to think), but to create a rival set of institutions conducted by the Company or by the Indian people in order that there may be "a reliable counterpoise, a protecting break-water against the threatened deluge of missionary enterprise". This object was generally kept in view between 1813 and 1853. That is to say, the Company spent the annual grant of a lakh of rupees (ten lakhs from 1833 on wards) in

¹*Vide* Nurullah and Naik: *History of Education in India during the British Period*, pp. 177-8.

maintaining its own institutions and only rarely did it sanction any grants-in-aid to mission schools. Consequently, the two systems of modern schools, viz., (a) the mission schools with their insistence on Bible-teaching and (b) the exclusively secular schools conducted by the Company grew up independently of each other between 1813 and 1853.

It soon became apparent that the schools of the Company would prove serious rivals to the mission schools. The former were secular and hence more popular with the Indian people than the mission schools whose emphasis on proselytization and Bible-teaching was both disliked and feared. Moreover, the schools of the Company could command large financial resources which the missions could never hope to do. The missionaries, therefore, realised that unless the competition between their schools and those of the Company was put an end to and unless their financial resources were strengthened, they had no chance of survival. They, therefore, put forward the following claims

(a) The Company's schools were secular, i.e., "godless" or "heathen" in the usual missionary parlance. Such schools were positively harmful and, therefore, the Bible must be taught in all the schools of the Company;

(b) If this were not possible on political grounds, it was argued that the Company should withdraw from direct educational enterprise and leave the field clear for the mission schools;

(c) It was also argued that the Company's schools were necessarily costlier, so that it would be wiser to spend the available limited resources in giving grants-in-aid to mission schools than in maintaining State institutions;

(d) The missions, it was claimed, had always a *moral* right to receive grant-in-aid from the Company. It was, therefore, argued that this moral right should be made a *legal* one by passing a Grant-in-aid Code under which an adequate financial assistance would be assured to every mission school;

(e) Finally, it was claimed that the ideal state of affairs in India would be one in which the Company would withdraw completely from direct educational enterprise and *all* the institutions required by the country would be provided by the missions on a grant-in-aid basis.

These claims ignored the private Indian enterprise altogether and were based on the misconception that the missions could do for India what the Churches did for the poor in England. But it took some years to realise these fallacies. For the time being, however, missionary influence in England and India was so strong and the relations between the officials of the Company and the missionaries were so cordial that all these claims were accepted in principle, as we shall soon see, by the Despatch of 1854.

Private Educational Enterprise by British Officials and Non-officials: We discussed missionary enterprise first because it was the oldest, and in so far as this period is concerned, the most extensive non-official agency in modern education. But the missionaries were not the only Europeans to work for modern education in India. To their group we must add a large number of British officials of the Company who worked in their individual capacity and a few British non-officials, chiefly businessmen, who assisted the cause of education either as a hobby or as a form of social service. Some of them sympathised with the missionary ideals and methods and assisted them. Their work need not be discussed here because it entirely partook of the character of the missionary endeavours which have already been discussed. But there were several British officials and non-officials who could not lend support to the missionaries either because they believed in secular schools or because they wanted to encourage private enterprise among the Indian people themselves. The work of this small group of British officials and non-officials is even more significant than that of the missionaries although it is far less in quantity and deserves a close analysis.

Curiously enough, the pioneer British gentleman who tried to build up new educational system for India, but on a plan different from that of the missionaries, was a humble watchmaker and jeweller from Calcutta, David Hare (1775-1842). His early education was far from satisfactory and he was not therefore, a "scholar" in the usually accepted sense of the term although he was generally well informed and had read some of the best English authors. Quite modestly, he used to describe himself as

“an uneducated man friendly to education”.¹ He came to India in 1800 and by 1815 had earned enough to enable him to retire from his profession. Instead of returning to England, however, he decided to stay on in Calcutta and devote the remainder of his life to the improvement of the people of India. What interested him more than anything else was the spread of education. Hare believed, like the missionaries, that a knowledge of the English language and an acquaintance with English literature was essential for the regeneration of the Hindu society; but being a secularist himself, he could not agree with them on the subject of religious instruction. It was, therefore, his view that India needed secular schools and colleges teaching the mother-tongue and English and spreading knowledge of English literature among the people. He had a contempt for Sanskrit and no great regard for scientific studies and, therefore, excluded them from his programme almost completely. It was to show the utility and practicability of such an experiment that he worked with zest all his life and carried out his most important educational project, the *Hindu Vidyalaya or College*. The most important object of this institution was to provide good English education to the sons of Hindu gentlemen and it was unique in two respects: firstly, it was conducted by a committee consisting of Europeans and Indians and secondly, it was the first great attempt to provide collegiate education of the Western type on a purely secular basis. Owing to financial difficulties, however, the Vidyalaya was later handed over to the Company for management and became the Presidency College in 1854. But its early history is of great historical importance because it shows how attempts to provide secular education became more popular with the Indian people and brought forth their willing co-operation in all respects.

The main contribution of Hare to the cause of modern education is the principle of secularism. He found that all educational enterprise of his time was dominated by religion—the institutions conducted by the Company (like the Banaras Sanskrit College or Calcutta Madrasah) were dominated by the teaching of Hinduism and Islam, while the missionary institutions were dominated by Christianity. He was convinced that both these types were unsatisfactory and evolved a new system in which Bengali and English

¹H.V. Hampton: *Biographical Studies in Modern Indian Education*, p.60.

would be taught rather than Sanskrit and Arabic and all religious education would be positively eschewed. His contempt for Sanskrit was responsible for the exclusion of Oriental studies and his lack of scholarship for the neglect of the sciences. The whole object of the institution, therefore, was to emphasise the study of English language and literature. The institution met with a strong opposition from several quarters in the early stages. The exclusion of Oriental studies enraged conservative Indians; the failure to emphasise the study of science alienated the sympathies of others, while the missionaries challenged the desirability of excluding all religious instruction. But very soon, the practical advantages of Hare's concept became patent and the model of the Hindu Vidyalaya came to be generally adopted by the Company as well as by private Indian enterprise. The Company found that the principle of secularism enabled it to maintain its policy of religious neutrality, while the emphasis on the study of English language and literature enabled it to obtain servants for the Government Departments where English was being adopted as the language of business. Private Indian enterprise also found it convenient to follow the model of the Hindu Vidyalaya because a policy of secular education involved no administrative problems and because a subordination of scientific studies made the conduct of the institutions less costly and difficult. For several years to come, therefore, the modern educational institutions started in India, either by the Company or by private Indian enterprise, were based on Hare's model of the Hindu Vidyalaya, that is to say, secular educational institutions whose chief object was to acquaint the students with English language and literature. Scientific and Oriental studies were included later on in varying proportions, and to that extent, the original design of Hare may be said to have been modified by later developments. But his concept of secularism remains the prominent feature of all Government (and most private Indian institutions as well) even to this day.

David Hare was a non-official and could, therefore, chalk out his own policy with freedom. The officials of the Company, on the other hand, had to work under several limitations. They could not, for obvious reasons undertake any activity to which the Company was *directly* opposed. But they could certainly engage *indirectly* in any activity to which the Company did not

object but which, for some reason on the other, it refused directly to undertake. Several broad-minded officials, therefore, organised or assisted, in their individual capacity, such educational projects as the Company would not countenance or support but which, in their opinion, were essential to the progress of India. A good illustration of this type of work is provided in the life of *J.E.D. Bethune* (1801-51) who was the Law-member of the Executive Council of the Governor-General and the President of the Council of Education from 1848 to 1851. He was keenly interested in the education of women but as the Company was not prepared to countenance any effort at the education of women, the channel of official enterprise was closed to him. Bethune was also convinced that respectable Hindus would never educate their daughters in the mission schools because of the missionary insistence on religious instruction. He, therefore, decided to establish a secular school for Indian girls in his own individual capacity and to bear all the expenses thereof.

The success of the school which began to function in May 1849 was almost phenomenal. Within a short time, it attracted a fairly large number of girls whose eagerness to learn, docility and quickness corresponded, in the opinion of Bethune, to those of the boys and even surpassed "what is found among European girls of the same age".¹ But even more important were two other results: enlightened Indians at once came forward to support the experiment and the example of the school began to be copied elsewhere. Bethune died at Calcutta in 1851 and, in his will endowed the school with all the lands and property he had in the city. It was then taken over by Lord Dalhousie who paid for it from his own private purse until the Company took it over. As a proper tribute to this great man, the school was permanently associated with his name and it soon developed into the Bethune College—a pioneer and important institution for the education of Indian women.

This experiment is but an instance from several educational experiments made by British officials working in their individual capacity. They are too numerous to be mentioned in a book of this type; and cover, not only education, but other branches of social service as well. Bethune's school should, therefore, be

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, p. 53.

regarded, not as an individual institution, but as representative of a group of institutions started and financed by officials in their individual capacity, because their views were not acceptable either to the Company or to the missionaries. These attempts, it should be noted, exercised a greater influence on the Indian mind, on account of their transparent sincerity and secular character, than those made either by the Company or the proselytizing missionaries.

Of a different type was the experiment made by Mountstuart Elphinstone in Bombay. When he became Governor of the Province in 1819, he found that the only non-official body (excluding the missions) which tried to provide modern education to the people was the Bombay Education Society. This had been established in 1815 by members of the Church of England resident in Bombay with the principal object of training Anglo-Indian or poor European children. It began its activities by taking over the Charity School established in Bombay by Rev. Richard Cobbe in 1719 and by starting others. As the society admitted Indian children also to its schools without compelling them to be present at religious instruction, many Hindu, Parsee and Muslim children attended them. By 1820, the Society conducted four schools for Indian children with about 250 pupils on their rolls. In the same year, the Society appointed a special committee. The objects of this Committee were twofold; to improve existing schools for Indian children and establish or aid new ones—wherever necessary; and secondly, to prepare books for the use of Indian children under instruction. By 1822, the Society's work for Indian children had grown considerably and it, therefore, rightly felt that it had undertaken activities which went far beyond its original aims. Hence the special Committee appointed by it two years earlier was now formed into a separate Society called the Bombay Native School Book and School Society (known by the handier epithet of *Bombay Native Education Society* since 1827), to look after the education of Indian children and the parent Society restricted its activities to the education of European or Anglo-Indian children only. It was mainly the encouragement and guidance of Mountstuart Elphinstone that was responsible for this independent organisation of the B.N.E. Society. He also agreed to be its President and made

the Directors sanction a grant-in-aid to the Society and accept it as the principal agency for the spread of education among the Indian people. It would be no exaggeration to say that it was this paternal interest of Elphinstone that enabled the B.N.E. Society to develop into an august body and, through its activities give practical training to Indians in organising and conducting associations for the spread of education.

These efforts of Elphinstone show how some of the broad-minded officials of this period tried to develop private Indian enterprise in modern education. They were convinced that neither missionaries nor the Company could provide *all* the educational institutions which the country needed that, after all, a people must educate themselves; that the very attempts to educate themselves form an important type of social education which a people can never obtain through a ready-made system of schools provided by an alien agency; and that private Indian enterprise must ultimately be developed to provide the bulk of the new educational institutions which were necessary to regenerate the country. They, therefore, took measures to bring forth and develop private Indian enterprise in education. The Indians of this period, it must be noted, were new to the modern methods of co-operative and organised educational enterprise and needed both initiation and guidance. This came readily from those enlightened officials of the Company who had a sense of duty to the country. They contacted leading Indians, convinced them of the necessity of private educational enterprise on modern lines, and showed them how to form and conduct societies for the purpose. Such a guidance was both necessary and valuable and could not have come from the missionaries partly because of their desire to monopolise the field and partly because of their insistence on Bible-teaching; and had it not been for the fostering care of officials working in their individual capacity, private Indian enterprise in education would have taken a very much longer time to develop.

Private Indian Enterprise in Education (1813-53): Prior to 1854, private Indian enterprise in education was responsible for two entirely different types of activities. The first of these was the conduct of the indigenous schools—both higher and elementary—which still formed the most widely spread, the most numerous

and the most important agency for the education of the people. But these were neither recognised nor assisted by the Company and in so far as the development of the modern system of education is concerned, this extensive activity of private Indian enterprise will just have to be ignored. The second type of private Indian enterprise was that which went to the building up of the modern system of education in India—an activity wherein, prior to 1854, Indians played a very minor role. This was due to a variety of circumstances. To begin with, the whole weight of conservative opinion was against the new system of education. The orthodox parents refused to send their children to English schools because they were afraid that English education made young men lose faith in the religious beliefs and practices of their forefathers—a fear that was not quite groundless. They even objected to the ideas from Western knowledge which were being spread through the Indian languages in the new type of primary schools and feared that all this new education was part of some secret plan to tamper with their religion. In these circumstances, it required an immense amount of moral courage to come forward to preach the utility of the new education or to conduct institutions based on the new ideals, and very few individuals could have such courage. Secondly, the educational institutions of the modern type could only be conducted by persons who were educated in the new system. The number of such Indians was very small and most of them could easily find a job in some important Government Department which at once brought them money, social status and executive authority. They were, therefore, naturally unwilling to start and conduct private schools which then, as now, were but an ill-paid form of social service. Thirdly, there were certain concepts prevalent at this time which created special difficulties for Indian private enterprise, e.g., it was believed that the Principals of English schools and colleges must be Europeans. This requirement could easily be fulfilled by the Company or by the missionaries. But how could Indians, even if they raised the necessary funds, find European employees to superintend their schools and colleges? This was probably the biggest stumbling block and it was overcome only when Government stopped demanding the employment of Europeans as Heads of schools and colleges and a band of Indians competent to hold

such posts was created. But this result could be achieved only by 1880 or thereafter and in so far as the period under review is concerned, Indian private enterprise was at a great handicap in the conduct of secondary and collegiate institutions. Lastly, Indians were new to the co-operative organisation of educational institutions and were just having their first lessons in conducting modern educational institutions at the hands of a few liberal officials and non-officials, here and there, and they had not yet pooled together enough experience to show any substantial results. It is, therefore, hardly a matter of surprise that modern educational institutions conducted by Indians formed a very small minority even in 1854. What matters to students of history, therefore, is not the quantitative, but the qualitative and ideological aspects of Indian private enterprise and these can be very well illustrated through the life of Raja Ram Mohan Roy.

Raja Ram Mohan Roy (1772-1833): Born in Radhanagar he was aptly described as the Father of Modern India. He came from an ancient and respectable Brahmin family and before he was sixteen years old, acquired a thorough knowledge of Sanskrit, Persian and Arabic. His study of sufi philosophy and the Koran had brought about such a change of views in him that endless disputes arose with his orthodox father and he, therefore, left his home and wandered about India for 3 or 4 years studying the religious beliefs and social practices of the people. But a conciliation soon took place and he returned home. Already in 1796, he had begun the study of English and later on, he also studied Hebrew and Greek in order to be able to study the New and Old Testaments in the original. In 1803, he lost his father and, in the following year, he joined the service of the Company and, by his industry and ability, soon rose to the post of the Dewan—the highest post in the Revenue Department then open to Indians. He amassed a moderate fortune and in 1814 retired from service in order to devote all his time to the service of his motherland.

The next twenty years—between his retirement in 1814 and death at Bristol in 1833—form a crowded era of public service. Ram Mohan Roy's work touched several aspects of Indian life, and the following important services rendered by him to the country may be mentioned here:

(a) He was a staunch opponent of the cruel custom of *sati* and lent strong and valuable support to Bentinck in abolishing it.

(b) He stood for a more equitable and humane treatment of women; advocated the grant of property rights to them; was a champion of their education; roundly condemned polygamy and, in his will, disinherited any son or descendant who would have more than one wife at a time; had his granddaughter married at the age of 16 and was obviously opposed to child-marriage; had no faith in the alleged inferiority of women. In short, he was one of the earliest champions of women's rights in modern India and started a movement for their emancipation which gathered great momentum later on.

(c) He was a great religious reformer. Being a student of comparative religion, he found that all religions had several common points. On the basis of his study, he evolved a purificatory movement within Hinduism itself—the Brahmo Samaj. As Rabindranath Tagore observes, "He extended wide his heart, and invited Hindu, Mussalman and Christian there, for in the expanse of his heart there was no lack of space for any one of them. In this it was the real heart of India that he revealed and expressed in himself her truest character. For the truth of India is in the man who honours all and accepts all in his heart."¹

(d) He was a pioneer among the nation-builders of modern India. He visualised an educated, cultured, rich and free India and tried to carry out certain reforms in the administrative system of his day. He advocated the use of English in law-courts, trial by jury, separation of the executive from the judiciary, and codification of criminal and other laws. As editor of the Bengali Journal, *Sambad Kaumudi*, published in 1821, he may be regarded as the virtual "Founder of Modern Indian Press" whose liberty he strongly defended against official attacks.

We are more concerned here with the work of Raja Ram Mohan Roy as an educationist, and it is in this field that we find his most signal services to his country. He was one of the earliest Indians to realise that India's greatest need was a *synthesis* of Eastern and Western cultures. Being a great Sanskrit scholar himself and having been deeply convinced of the truth and greatness of the ancient and pure form of Hinduism, he would not

¹*The Father of Modern India*, p. 232.

be a party to the wholesale condemnation of Eastern culture and religion which was so fashionable in missionary circles, nor would he subscribe to the view that the Eastern culture must be replaced by the Western. At the same time, he understood that the Indian mind had rusted very considerably on account of its isolation and realised that contact with Western literature and science alone could regenerate Oriental culture, correct its follies and contribute to it the essential qualities which it lacked. He, therefore, saw (together with a few other men of vision) "the need of a new synthesis of the best that Europe and Asia had to give and strove, consequently, to weave into the tapestry of Indian life such threads from the spindles of the West, without bringing about a complete alteration in the pattern upon the Indian loom".¹ This great vision makes the Raja a prophet of modern India. It is true that this advice went unheeded for a time; but ultimately, it triumphed.

The second great contribution of the Raja to the modern system of education was to popularise a study of English language and through it, of Western science and literature. Although a great Sanskrit scholar himself, he deprecated all the official attempts to educate Indians through Sanskrit and Arabic and, as stated already in Chapter III, petitioned the Government to abandon its project for Oriental education and to undertake the teaching of Western science and literature instead. It is true that he can claim no originality for this view and that it had already been put forward by men like Grant. But it must be remembered that the Raja's advocacy of the study of English and Western science and literature produced effects which were different from anything that had gone before. In the first place, he was a Hindu talking to other Hindus and this consideration alone made his appeal far stronger and more powerful than that of missionaries or officials whose motives were generally suspect. Secondly, he could overcome several fears which prevented the contemporary Hindu society from taking freely to the study of English or Western science and literature. The orthodox Hindus were afraid that such studies might make a young man an atheist, or a convert to Christianity or an unbalanced rebel against all tradition. The early examples of some

¹Earl of Ronaldshay: *The Heart of Aryavarta*, p. 48.

educated Hindu youths confirmed these fears. Some of them became actual converts to Christianity; others remained within the Hindu fold but lost all devotion to traditional religion; while a large number led culturally unsettled lives and delighted in exhibiting the so-called *Western virtues* of eating beef or drinking wine. Ram Mohan Roy showed, both by precept and example, that these consequences were not inevitable in Western education. He proved that a synthesis of Eastern and Western cultures was possible and although his *method* of the synthesis was not acceptable to many, he could convince his co-religionists that Western education was not always culturally dangerous as it was supposed to be. He thus acted as one of the earliest *Indian* interpreters of the West to India.

Thirdly, he did an equal or even more valuable service in interpreting India to England. He tried his utmost to dispel the absurd notions which then prevailed regarding the nature of Hinduism, the poverty of the ancient literatures in Sanskrit, the lack of character and moral values among Indians, etc. His great learning, unimpeachable character, lucid and convincing exposition of his deep religious beliefs showed to Englishmen that it would be wrong to condemn summarily all Eastern learning and religion and that a judicious study of Oriental culture ought to have a place in the modern educational system of India—a view that was later on accepted by the Despatch of 1854 as well.

The fourth great contribution of the Raja to the system of modern education was his emphasis on the study of modern Indian languages. He himself gave a great lead in the matter by writing books in Bengali on Grammar, Geography, Astronomy and Geometry and he is considered as the father of modern literary Bengali prose. He was also the first to write theistic poems in Bengali. His advocacy of the study and development of modern Indian languages, although unheeded for a long time, was certainly a great contribution to the educational thought of his times.

Equally able was the Raja's advocacy of the education of women. Although the concept had already been put forward by missionaries, it was the Raja who helped to popularise it among the Hindus. He took his stand on the old *shastras* and convincingly showed that in ancient times, the women of India were highly educated and that the education of women was in keeping

with ancient religious traditions and beliefs. The Brahmo Samaj did great service in removing the popular prejudices against the education of women that were then prevalent in the Hindu society and the credit for this goes mostly to Ram Mohan Roy.

In 1830, the Raja went to England and gave very valuable evidence before the Select Committee of the House of Commons in 1833. In this last great act of his life the Raja urged, among other reforms, the codification of civil and criminal laws and the appointment of Indians to important posts under Government. Both these proposals were accepted and incorporated in the Charter Act of 1833. In order to carry out the first, a Law-Member was added to the Council of the Governor-General and a little later, Macaulay came out to India as the first person to hold the post. On the second proposal, the Raja had lodged a strong protest against the policy of excluding Indians from all but the inferior posts under Government. This view of the only Indian who was in a position to place it before Parliament was also supported by several other British witnesses before the Committee and was, therefore, accepted without much difficulty. Section 87 of the Charter Act of 1833 provided "that no native of the said territories, nor any natural born subject of his Majesty resident therein, shall, by reason only of his religion, place of birth, descent, colour, or any of them, be disabled from holding any place, office, or employment under the said Company".

Unfortunately, this clause mostly remained on paper for several years. But that does not detract in any way from the signal service which the Raja did to the cause of political regeneration of India by making Parliament accept, in principle at least, the doctrine of the Indianisation of key-posts under Government.

It is for these and other valuable services that the Raja is called "The Father of Modern India".

The Despatch of 1854: It will be seen from the events of the period between 1813 and 1853 narrated in this and the preceding chapter that, by 1853, a stage had been reached when a comprehensive survey of the whole field of education in India was indispensable. Since the Charter Act of 1813, several educational experiments had been tried; a number of agencies had been at work, in their own ways, to spread education among the people;

several controversies had been raised and some of them still needed a final decision; various policies for action had been proposed and they involved controversial issues which needed careful consideration. It was, in short, a time when the best results could be obtained only by holding a thorough and comprehensive review of the past and by prescribing in the light of this review, a detailed policy for educational reconstruction in the future. This was exactly what the Education Despatch of 1854 did.

The occasion for the Despatch was provided by the renewal of the Company's Charter in 1853. At this time, as at the earlier renewals of the Charter in 1813 and 1833, a Select Committee of the House of Commons held a very thorough enquiry into educational developments in India. On the basis of this enquiry, the Court of Directors sent down their greatest Educational Despatch on 19 July 1854. This document of immense historical importance is sometimes described as *Wood's Education Despatch* because it was probably written at the instance of Charles Wood who was then the President of the Board of Control. It is a long document of a hundred paragraphs and deals with several questions of great educational importance.

Objects of Educational Policy: To begin with, the Despatch explains why the Company undertook the organisation of education in India and the results that it expected therefrom:

Among many subjects of importance, none can have a stronger claim to our attention than that of education. It is one of our most sacred duties, to be the means, as far as in us lies, of conferring upon the natives of India those vast moral and material blessings which flow from the general diffusion of useful knowledge, and which India may, under Providence, derive from her connexion with England. . . .

We have, moreover, always looked upon the encouragement of education peculiarly important, because calculated "not only to produce a higher degree of intellectual fitness, but to raise the moral character of those who partake of its advantages, and so to supply you with servants to whose probity you may with increased confidence commit offices of trust". . . .

Nor, while the character of England is deeply concerned in

the success of our efforts for the promotion of education, are her material interests altogether unaffected by the advance of European knowledge in India; this knowledge will teach the natives of India the marvellous results of the employment of labour and capital, rouse them to emulate us in the development of the vast resources of their country, guide them in their efforts, and gradually, but certainly, confer upon them all the advantages which accompany the healthy increase of wealth and commerce; and, at the same time, secure to us a large and more certain supply of many articles necessary for our manufactures and extensively consumed by all classes of our population, as well as an almost inexhaustible demand for the produce of British labour.

Controversy between the Anglicists and Classicists: The Despatch then refers to the controversy between the Classicists and Anglicists in Bengal. It is worthy of note that the Despatch does not condemn the view of the Oriental party in a summary fashion as Macaulay did. It appreciates the advantages that spring from a study of the classical languages of India, and admits that "an acquaintance with the works contained in them is valuable for historical and antiquarian purposes, and a knowledge of the languages themselves is required in the study of Hindoo and Mahomedan law, and is also of great importance for the critical cultivation and improvement of the vernacular languages of India". It also mentions "the success of many distinguished Oriental scholars in their praiseworthy endeavours to engraft upon portions of Hindoo philosophy the gems of sounder morals and of more advanced science;" ... and "the good effect which has thus been produced upon the learned classes of India, who pay hereditary veneration to those ancient languages" Nevertheless, the Despatch agrees with Lord Macaulay and points out that "the system of science and philosophy which forms the learning of the East abounds with grave errors, and Eastern literature is at best very deficient as regards all modern discovery and improvement;" and concludes the discussion with the following declaration:

We must emphatically declare that the education which we

desire to see extended in India is that which has for its object the diffusion of the improved arts, science, philosophy and literature of Europe; in short of European knowledge.

Medium of Instruction: The question of the medium of instruction is next dealt with. The Despatch first explains how it became necessary in the beginning to use English as a medium of instruction "owing to the want of translations or adaptations of European works in the vernacular languages of India to the very imperfect shape in which European knowledge is to be found in any works in the learned languages of the East". It admits, however, that one evil result of the measure had been to create a tendency to neglect the study of the "vernacular languages". The Despatch was used as a medium of instruction by the Company merely to suppress indigenous education or to discourage the study of Indian languages and shows how English and Indian languages *together* may help to spread proper education in India. It says:

In any general system of education, English language should be taught where there is a demand for it; but such instruction should always be combined with a careful attention to the study of the vernacular language of the district, and with such general instruction as can be conveyed through that language; and while the English language continues to be made use of as by far the most perfect *medium* for the education of those persons who have acquired a sufficient knowledge of it to receive general instruction *through* it, the vernacular languages must be employed to teach the far larger classes who are ignorant of, or imperfectly acquainted with, English. This can only be done effectually through the instrumentality of masters and professors, who may, by themselves, knowing English and thus having full access to the latest improvements in knowledge of every kind, impart to their countrymen, through the medium of their mother-tongue, the information which they have thus obtained. At the same time, and as the importance of the vernacular becomes more appreciated, the vernacular literature of India will be gradually enriched by translations of European books or by the original compositions of men whose minds have been imbued with the

spirit of European advancement, so that European knowledge may gradually be placed in this manner within the reach of all classes of the people. We look, therefore, to the English language and to the vernacular languages of India together as the media for the diffusion of European knowledge, and it is our desire to see them cultivated together in all schools in India of a sufficiently high class to maintain a schoolmaster possessing the requisite qualifications.

It will be seen that all the three problems dealt with in the Despatch so far are old controversies, and that the Despatch does nothing more than to sum up the conclusions already reached.

New Schemes: (a) *The Education Department:* The Despatch then proceeds to explain the new schemes that were to be introduced. The first of these was the creation of a Department of Public Instruction in each of the five provinces into which the territory of the Company were divided at that time, viz., Bengal, Madras, Bombay, the North-Western Province and the Punjab. This department was to be placed under an important officer to be called the Director of Public Instruction. He was to be assisted by an adequate number of Inspecting Officers and was required to submit to Government an annual report on the progress of education in his province.

(b) *Universities:* The second scheme related to the establishment of Universities. As we have already seen, the proposal for the establishment of a University at Calcutta made by the Council of Education in 1854 was negatived by the Directors on the ground that it was then premature. But now they felt that the time for the establishment of Universities had arrived, because of the spread of liberal education among Indians and the requirements of an increasing European and Anglo-Indian population. The Despatch, therefore, directs that universities should be established at Calcutta and Bombay and states that the Directors were "ready to sanction the creation of a University at Madras, or in any part of India, where a sufficient number of institutions exist, from which properly qualified candidates for degrees could be supplied". All the Universities were to be modelled on the London University which

was then an examining body. Their senates were to consist of a Chancellor, a Vice-Chancellor, and Fellows—all of whom were to be nominated by Government. The functions of the Universities were *mainly* to hold examinations and confer degrees. But it is extremely interesting to note that even at this early date the Despatch advised the institution of professorships in various branches of learning.

(c) *Establishment of a Network of Graded Schools all over India:* Having described the two new schemes mentioned above, viz., the creation of the Education Department and the establishment of Universities, the Despatch proceeds to explain the network of graded schools which the Directors desired to spread all over the country. At one end of this gradation came the University and the affiliated colleges which gave instruction in various branches of art and science. Below these, came the high schools which gave instruction either through English or through a modern Indian language, and at the bottom came the indigenous primary schools.

The Despatch admitted that most of the attempts of Government in the past had been directed to the establishment of colleges which absorbed the greater part of the public funds that were then applied to education, and regretted the adoption of the Downward Filtration Theory which led "to too exclusive a direction of the efforts of Government towards providing the means of acquiring a very high degree of education for a very small number of natives of India drawn, for the most part, from the higher classes". After stating that these higher classes may now be made to stand on their own legs, the Despatch observes:

Our attention should now be directed to a consideration, if possible, still more important, and one which has been hitherto, we are bound to admit, too much neglected, namely, how useful and practical knowledge, suited to every station of life, may be best conveyed to the great mass of the people, who are utterly incapable of obtaining any education worthy of the name, by their own unaided efforts, and we desire to see the active measures of Government more especially directed, for the future, to this object, for the attainment of which we are ready to sanction a considerable increase of expenditure.

To achieve this purpose, the Directors recommended a multiplication of High Schools. It is not generally understood that the Despatch visualised High Schools which imparted good general education through the Indian languages, but the following paragraph will make the whole position clear:

We include these Anglo-vernacular and vernacular schools in the same class, because we are unwilling to maintain the broad line of separation which at present exists between schools in which the media for imparting instruction differ. The knowledge conveyed is no doubt, at the present time, much higher in the Anglo-vernacular than in the vernacular schools; but the difference will become less marked, and the latter more efficient as the gradual enrichment of the vernacular languages in works of education allows their schemes of study to be enlarged, and as a more numerous class of schoolmasters is raised up, able to impart a superior education.

Below the High and Middle Schools came the indigenous elementary schools which the Directors proposed to encourage by suitable grant-in-aid. In this connection, the Directors drew the attention of the Government of India to the plan for encouraging indigenous schools adopted by Thomason in the North-Western Province and recommended its adoption as largely as possible.

As a connecting link between these various grades of schools, it was proposed to institute scholarships to be given to promising pupils in order to enable them to continue their studies at a higher school or college. As the Despatch observes:

Such a system as this, placed in all its degrees under efficient inspection, beginning with the humblest elementary instruction, and ending with the university test of a liberal education, the best students in each class of schools being encouraged by the aid afforded them towards obtaining superior education as the reward of merit, by means of such a system of scholarships as we shall have to describe, would, we firmly believe, impart life and energy to education in India and lead to a gradual, but steady extension of its benefits to all classes of the people.

The above proposals of the Despatch have three important features—the rejection of the Downward Filtration Theory, the adoption of the modern Indian languages as media of instruction at the secondary stage, and the inclusion of indigenous schools as the very foundation of a national system of education. In all these principles, the Despatch marked a reversal of the retrograde policy laid down by Lord Auckland.

(d) *Grant-in-Aid*: Excellent as this scheme was, it was obvious that, when fully carried out, it would have involved the Company in an enormous expenditure which it would not have been able to bear without additional taxation. Unfortunately, the Directors shirked to face this problem squarely. They made a non-committal remark that they were prepared to sanction “a considerable increase in expenditure” for their new programme and naively believed that a policy of giving grant-in-aid to private effort would solve the difficulties in Indian education as it had solved those of mass education in England. They said:

The consideration of the impossibility of Government alone doing all that must be done in order to provide adequate means for the education of the natives of India, and of the ready assistance which may be derived from efforts which have hitherto received but little encouragement from the State, has led us to the natural conclusion that the most effectual method of providing for the wants of India in this respect will be to combine with the agency of the Government the aid which may be derived from the exertions and the liberality of the educated and wealthy natives of India, and of other benevolent persons.

We have, therefore, resolved to adopt in India the system of grants-in-aid which has been carried out in this country with very great success; and we confidently anticipate by thus drawing support from local resources, in addition to contributions from the State, a far more rapid progress of education than would follow a mere increase of expenditure by Government; while it possesses the additional advantage of fostering a spirit of reliance upon local exertions and combination for local purposes, which is of itself of no mean importance to the well-being of a nation.

The Despatch then suggests certain general considerations in the light of which each Provincial Government was expected to frame its own rules of grant-in-aid. For instance, aid was to be given to all schools which

- (i) impart a good secular education, any religious instruction which they may impart being simply ignored;
- (ii) possess good local management;
- (iii) agree to submit to inspection by Government officers and to abide by such other conditions as may be prescribed; and
- (iv) levy a fee, however small, from the pupils.

The discussion of the subject is then concluded in the following words:

We look forward to the time when any general system of education entirely provided by Government may be discontinued, with the gradual advance of the system of grant-in-aid, and when many of the existing Government institutions, especially those of the higher order, may be safely closed, or transferred to the management of local bodies under the control of, and aided by, the State.

One wonders at this emphasis on a grant-in-aid system at a time when Indian enterprise had hardly begun and missionary enterprise was quite out of proportion to the needs of the population. But the following comment of a missionary on this part of the Despatch is illuminating:

In connection with the second definite move in the new Indian educational policy, the famous "Educational Despatch" of Sir Chas. Wood (later Lord Halifax) on July 19th, 1854, Duff exercised, along with his distinguished friend Sir Chas. Trevelyan, a definite influence. When the protracted and complicated negotiations anterior to the last renewal of the East India Charter were going on in 1852, Duff was in England, and he was accepted, even in Government circles, as a supreme authority on Indian affairs. Frequently consulted

upon this question, he threw the whole weight of his personality into the balance in order that this *Magna Charta of Indian education* might pass into law. . . .

For missions too this grant-in-aid system was of great importance. Whereas formerly, in spite of the benevolent decrees of a Bentinck or a Hardinge, the Government had been loath to grant financial aid to mission schools, *missions now had the additional claim of a legal right*. And as missionaries like Dr. Duff had a distinct influence in the shaping of the famous Despatch, it was perfectly clear that the main tendency of the new grant-in-aid system was to encourage the various missions to engage in the very congenial work of elementary education to a larger extent than ever before.¹

In this connection, the attitude of the Despatch towards religious instruction is also worthy of note as it shows the official sympathy for missionary effort. So far as aided schools were concerned (which in those days meant missionary schools only) the Despatch desired that the Inspecting Officers should take "*no notice whatsoever . . . of the religious doctrines that may be taught in any school*". As regards Government institutions, the Despatch stated:

Considerable misapprehension appears to exist as to our views with respect to religious instruction in the Government institutions. Those institutions were founded for the benefit of the whole population of India; and in order to effect their object it was, and is, indispensable that the education conveyed in them should be exclusively secular. The Bible is, we understand, placed in the libraries of the colleges and schools and the pupils are able freely to consult it. This is as it should be; and, moreover, we have no desire to prevent, or discourage, any explanations which the pupils may, of their own free will, ask from the masters upon the subject of the Christian religion provided that such information be given out of school hours. Such instruction being entirely voluntary on both sides, it is necessary, in order to prevent the slightest suspicion of an intention on our part to make use of the influence of

¹Richter : *A History of Missions in India*, p. 180 (Italics ours).

Government for the purpose of proselytism, that no notice shall be taken of it by the inspectors in their periodical visits.

(e) *Training of Teachers:* The Despatch then proceeds to consider the question of securing properly qualified teachers for schools, and says:

We cannot do better than refer you to the plan which has been adopted in Great Britain for this subject, and which appears to us to be capable of easy adaptation to India. It mainly consists, as you will perceive on reference to the Minutes of the Committee of Council, copies of which we enclose, in the selection and stipend of pupil-teachers (awarding a small payment to the masters of the schools in which they are employed for the instruction out of school hours); their ultimate removal, if they prove worthy, to normal schools; the issue to them of certificates on the completion of their training in those normal schools; and in securing to them a sufficient salary when they are afterwards employed as school-masters. This system should be carried out in India, both in the Government colleges and schools, and, by means of grants-in-aid, in all institutions which are brought under Government inspection. . . .

Our wish is that the profession of schoolmaster may, for the future, afford inducements to the natives of India such as are held out in other branches of the public service.

Education and Employment: The question of giving encouragement to educated Indians is then taken up. The Despatch states:

We have always been of opinion that the spread of education in India will produce a greater efficiency in all branches of administration by enabling you to obtain the services of intelligent and trustworthy persons in every department of Government; and on the other hand, we believe that the numerous vacancies of different kinds which have constantly to be filled up, may afford a great stimulus to education. . . .

What we desire is that, where the other qualifications of the candidates for appointments under Government are equal, a

person who has received a good education, irrespective of the place or manner in which it may have been acquired, should be preferred to one who has not; and that even in lower situations, a man who can read and write be preferred to one who cannot if he is equally eligible in other respects.

But, however large the number of appointments under Government may be, the views of the natives of India should be directed to the far wider and more important sphere of usefulness and advantage which a liberal education lays open to them; and such practical benefits arising from improved knowledge should be constantly impressed upon them by those who know their feelings and have influence or authority to advise or direct their efforts.

Education of Women: Finally, the Despatch offers a few suggestions regarding some other problems of education. For instance, the Despatch points out the necessity of providing suitable school books in Indian languages; the importance of vocational instruction and to that end, the need of establishing vocational colleges and schools of Industry; and the urgency of spreading education among women. With regard to the last of these, the Despatch observes:

The importance of female education in India cannot be overrated; and we have observed with pleasure the evidence which is now afforded of an increased desire on the part of many of the natives of India to give a good education to their daughters. By this means a far greater proportional impulse is imparted to the educational and moral tone of the people than by the education of men. We have already observed that schools for females are included among those to which grants-in-aid may be given; and we cannot refrain from expressing our cordial sympathy with the efforts which are being made in this direction. Our Governor-General in Council has declared, in a communication to the Government of Bengal, that the Government ought to give to the native female education in India its frank and cordial support; and in this we heartily concur and we especially approve of the bestowal of marks of honour upon such native gentlemen as Rao Bahadur

Magahunbhai Karramchand who donated Rs. 20,000 to the foundation of two native female schools in Ahmedabad, as by such means our desire for the extension of female education becomes generally known.

Criticism of the Despatch: Such were the main provisions of this document of great historical importance. Its immediate effects were the creation of an Education Department in each province of British India and the establishment of Universities at Calcutta, Madras and Bombay. It gave an impetus to secondary education and to some extent, to primary education also. It introduced the system of grant-in-aid and led to the establishment of training institutions for teachers. The Despatch is the last and the most complete of a series of historical documents which includes Grant's Observations, Section 43 of the Charter Act of 1813, Minutes of Lord Minto, Lord Moira, Sir Charles Metcalfe, Elphinstone, Sir Thomas Munro, Lord Macaulay and Lord Auckland. It forms a fitting close to the second period in the history of Indian Education in which the foundations of the present education system were laid. It affords us an excellent platform from which we can take a retrospective glance at the past and, as the late M. R. Paranjpe observed, it enables us "to find out how far we have achieved the educational objectives which the authors of the Despatch had in view, and to note the changes brought about in our educational objectives in the last hundred years, partly by mere lapse of time and partly by the new environment created by the educational progress in the period".¹

It is a matter for regret that some of the most important recommendations of the Despatch were not carried out for a long time; some were given effect to in a mutilated form; while some more have yet to be acted upon. The encouragement of Indian languages which it promised remained a pious wish for a long time to come and the languages spoken and understood by the masses continued to languish. The desire of the Despatch to evolve a policy of grant-in-aid which would enable Government completely to withdraw from the field of educational activities was more observed in breach than in fulfilment. As the late M. R. Paranjpe observes:

¹*Progress of Education*, Poona, July 1941, p. 52.

For over sixty years, however, Government institutions gradually increased in number and private enterprise was often discouraged rather than encouraged. During the first thirty years, i.e., up to 1880, Christian missions were the only private agency in the field and Government did not have the courage to entrust the work of education to Christian missions whose primary aim was to secure converts to Christianity. The incidents of 1857 had demonstrated to Government the risk it ran in creating suspicion in people's mind regarding Government's attitude towards the religions of the people of India, and the Christian missions did not get the full measure of Government support although they continued to be the most favoured non-Government agency in the field of education.¹

With the spread of education and new ideals of social service, Indian private enterprise began and multiplied. But Government was not prepared to hand over its schools and colleges to Indian management either, because it did not believe in the capacity of Indians to conduct them efficiently.

To plans of mass education visualised by the Despatch were not realised, nor were High Schools imparting education through the medium of the mother-tongue established for more than seven decades. It may be pointed out that it is to these, and other omissions to give full effect to the provisions of the Despatch, that the origin of many of the defects of the present educational system can be traced.

It is also interesting to note how some of the sentiments expressed in the Despatch have grown obsolete. For instance, the Despatch speaks of education "suited to every station in life". This is quite intelligible as an ideal of the early Victorian era when people believed in a "beautiful social order Providentially arranged" in which each person had a definite status according to birth or environment. But the idea jars upon a modern thinker who believes in equality of educational opportunity for all. Similarly, one is pained to find that the Despatch can only think of the India to come as the supplier of raw materials for British industries and as the consumer of the finished products of England. This is a position which hardly any self-respecting

¹*Ibid.*, p. 47.

Indian would accept, either from the economic or educational point of view.

In pointing out these facts, let us not be misunderstood as belittling the work done or contemplated by the framers of the Despatch. We cannot, however, find any justification for the superlative terms in which some historians have described the Despatch and even called it "The Magna Charta of Indian Education". In our opinion, such a view betrays a lack of proportion. The Despatch, no doubt, did a lot towards the evolution of a good system of education in India according to the educational ideals then prevalent. But these ideals have changed so materially since then that it would help India very little to be now guided by the sentiments of the Despatch. As for calling it a Charter, one cannot do better than to quote the late M.R. Paranjpe who observes:

But in spite of all these good features it would be incorrect to describe the Educational Despatch of 1854 as an Educational Charter, *i.e.*, an official paper bestowing or guaranteeing certain rights and privileges. The Despatch does not ever refer to the ideal of universal literacy although it expects education to spread over a wider field through the grants-in-aid system; it does not recognize the obligation of the State to educate every child below a certain age; it does not declare that poverty shall be no bar to the education of deserving students; and while it may be admitted that employment in Government offices was not the object of English education as visualised in the Despatch, the authors did not aim at education for leadership, education for the industrial regeneration of India, education for the defence of the motherland, in short, education required by the people of a self-government nation. It was perhaps pardonable that the authors of the Despatch could not visualise the progress of Indian aspirations after a century—but that is admitting indirectly the imperfections of the Despatch. Whatever were its values in 1854, it would be ridiculous to describe the Despatch as an Educational Charter, in the year 1941.¹

¹*Progress of Education*, Poona, July 1941, pp. 51-2.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Victorian Era (I) (1854-1902)

The Despatch of 1854, was at first looked upon as the beginning of a great era of educational reforms under the East India Company. But, as events actually turned out, it proved to be its swan song. The Departments of Public Instruction were constituted in 1855-56 and the Universities were incorporated in 1857. But before any further action could be taken on the terms of the Despatch, the Company ceased to be a political power in 1858 and the Government of India came directly under the Crown. Broadly speaking, therefore, education in India under the East India Company may be taken to have ended with the Despatch of 1854 itself.

General Features of the Period from 1854 to 1902: The Despatch of 1854, as pointed out in the last chapter, took stock of the past and laid down long-range policies for future guidance. The directions of the Despatch continued to be followed in broad outline until the opening of the twentieth century when Lord Curzon started another new era in Indian education. The period of about five decades between the Despatch of 1854 and the appointment of the Indian Universities Commission by Lord Curzon in 1902 may, therefore, be described as the third period in modern education in India or, briefly, the *Victorian Era* in Indian Education.

As compared with India under the Company, this Victorian Era was a period of peace and tranquillity. Between 1813 and 1853, the main tasks of the British administrators were conquest and consolidation. It was, therefore, a period of almost continuous warfare. Anarchy and general unrest prevailed in several parts of India and law and order was restored only when these parts were conquered and brought directly under the British rule.